

Black heron

The black heron, or black egret, fishes for food in an unusual way. It spreads its wings out around its head to shade the water. The reason for this could be that the shaded area cuts out reflections on the surface of the water and makes it easier for the bird to see fish. Another explanation is that fish may swim into the dark patch thinking it is a safe shelter. When the heron spots a fish, it jabs its bill quickly into the water.

The bird makes an "umbrella" over the water with its wings for 2–3 seconds at a time by day or night.



Black heron
(*Egretta ardesiaca*)
Length: up to 2 ft 2 in (66 cm)

Long, thin bill to catch prey.

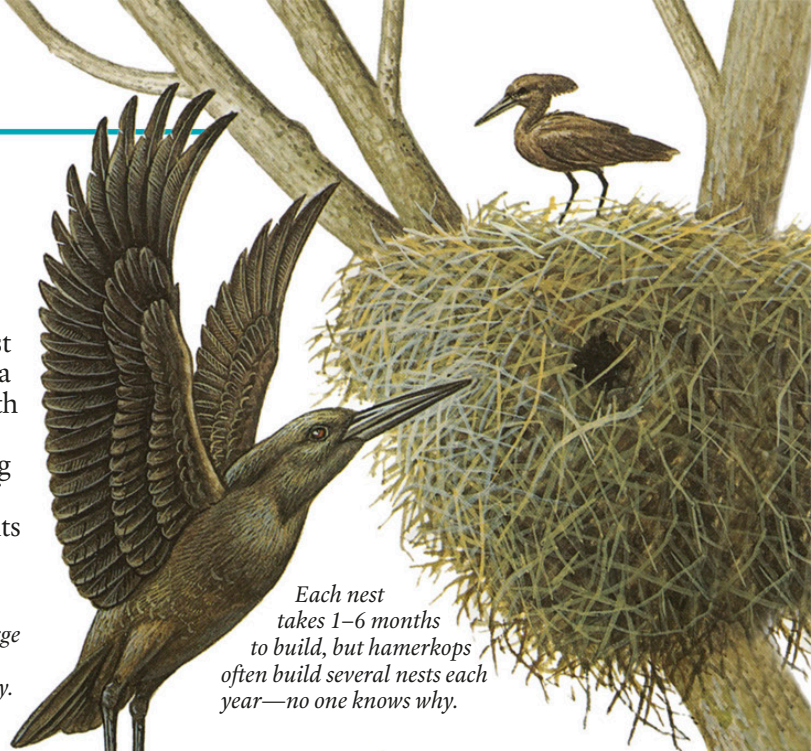
Hamerkop

This bird is named after its hammer-shaped head. It builds a huge, roofed nest of twigs, grass, and mud, usually high in a tree near water. The nest is decorated with feathers, bones, snakeskins, and trash that people have thrown away. It is strong enough for a person to stand on the roof without falling in. Chicks are safe inside its thick walls while the parents find food.

Short tail and large wings for gliding and soaring easily.

Toes are partly webbed.

Hamerkop
(*Scopus umbretta*)
Length: 1 ft 10 in (56 cm)



Each nest takes 1–6 months to build, but hamerkops often build several nests each year—no one knows why.

Huge head to support the massive bill.

Large eyes help see fish and other prey in the water.



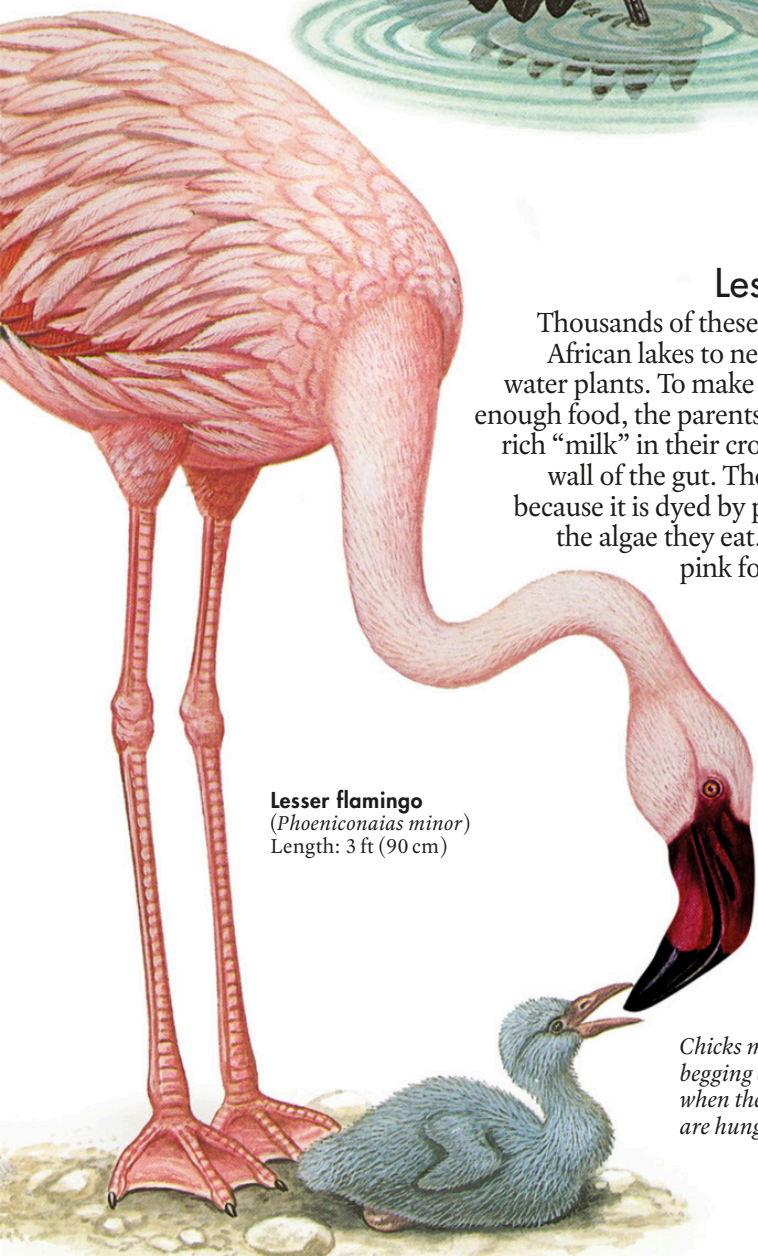
Shoebill
(*Balaeniceps rex*)
Length: 4 ft (1 m 20 cm)

Hook at tip of bill helps grab hold of wet, slippery food.

Lesser flamingo

Thousands of these flamingos flock to African lakes to nest and feed on tiny water plants. To make sure the chicks get enough food, the parents produce a kind of rich "milk" in their crop—a pouch in the wall of the gut. The milk is bright red because it is dyed by pink pigment from the algae they eat. Their feathers are pink for the same reason.

Lesser flamingo
(*Phoeniconaias minor*)
Length: 3 ft (90 cm)



Chicks make begging calls when they are hungry.

Shoebill

This bird is named for its extraordinary shoe-shaped bill. The huge bill helps the bird catch and hold its favorite food—lungfish. It also eats young crocodiles, turtles, frogs, and snakes. Parents sometimes collect water in their bills and pour it over their chicks in hot weather to keep them cool.

African jacana
(*Actophilornis africanus*)
Length: 1 ft (31 cm)

Long toes and claws spread out the bird's weight so it can walk on floating plants without sinking.

African jacana

These birds are also called lily-trotters. They run over floating plants pecking at the water and leaves to collect food. The male builds the nest, sits on the eggs, and takes care of the chicks, which is very rare for a male bird—female birds usually raise the young, often on their own.

